



Bulgaria

Education for All 2015 National Review

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Objective 1: Early preschool education and upbringing

How well do national policies, legislation, strategies and plans cover early preschool education and upbringing?

Education during early childhood years has a proven positive effect on the formation of good habits and social skills and the further development of a personality. It lays solid foundations for successful inclusion in the educational system. The Bulgarian state and municipalities exert consistent and targeted efforts for extending the coverage of children in kindergartens.

During the period from the year 2000 to 2014 preschool education has affirmed itself as a priority in the legislation and national policies of the Republic of Bulgaria .

By amendment of the Public Education Act /PEA/ as of school year 2010/2011 the mandatory two-year preparation course before the admission of 5 - year old children in the first grade has been regulated. Pursuant to Art. 20, para. 1 of PEA /effective as of 05.10.2010/ "The preschool preparation course for children two years before their admission to the first school grade is mandatory, but not earlier than the year of a child's fifth birthday." As of the school year 2012/2013 it has been introduced in all municipalities in the Republic of Bulgaria. The measure aims at providing equal start for every child and contributes to developing the skills being necessary upon admission to the first grade.

Policies, measures and activities related to the preschool upbringing and preparation are prescribed in documents of strategic significance to education.

In the *National programme for development of school education and preschool upbringing and preparation /2006 - 2015/* an emphasis is put on the significance of preschool upbringing and preparation, mostly in the period of obligatory preparation for school for the formation of positive attitude towards learning and the creation of motivation for learning especially in children living in an environment, in which education is not perceived as a value.

The programme is implemented by way of annual secondary education development programmes, among which there are such directed towards children at the mandatory preschool age.

In the ***Strategy for decreasing the share of early school leavers (2013-2020)*** policies and measures are laid out for prevention of dropping out from school and early school leaving, including such focused on education and cares in early childhood age. In pursuance of the objectives of the Strategy, it is expected to achieve results, among which: increased coverage by kindergartens and schools through encouragement of enrollment and regular attendance, offering inter-sector services for educational and social support; improved education results and provision of suitable educational support to every child and student.

In the implementation of the **National Roma Integration Strategy of the Republic of Bulgaria /2012-2020/**, the Ministry of Education and Science is a leading institution under the *Education* priority. The first objective under the *Education* priority in the Action Plan of the National Roma Integration Strategy of the Republic of Bulgaria (2012 - 2020) and Roma Inclusion Decade 2005-201 refers to *guaranteeing the right of equal access to quality education* . For its implementation it is envisaged to provide positive educational conditions for the children's development in the preschool education system /early childhood and pre-school age from 0 to 7 years/. In addition, activities are laid out for provision of appropriate educational environment for coverage of the children from the kindergartens separated on ethnic basis through stage-by-stage admission to kindergartens outside the Roma residential areas, in multiethnic groups and opening of hour-based, seasonal and weekend groups in kindergartens.

For increasing the quality of education, the aforementioned plan envisages activities related to the preparation of children of early age (3-6 years old) for their future successful inclusion in the educational process, especially of children from minority groups, as well as additional activities with children in kindergartens, for whom Bulgarian is not a native tongue. For the prevention of dropping out from school the plan prescribes measures for provision of conditions of maximal scope and early adaptation of the preschool education system. Also planned is the organization of campaigns for raising the awareness of parents from vulnerable communities as regards the benefits of preschool education.

The full integration of Roma children by way of desegregation of kindergartens in the separate Roma residential areas and the creation of conditions for equal access to quality education beyond them is a priority envisaged in the **Strategy for Educational Integration of Children and Students from Ethnic Minorities** /adopted in 2004 and updated in 2010/.

2. Is early preschool education and upbringing regarded as an integral part of the right of education within national legislation?

The Republic of Bulgaria recognizes the right of the child to education and guarantees through the legal framework equal treatment of children in respect of this right. In Art. 9, para. 1 of PEA it is specified that every citizen applies his/her right to education in a school of his/her own choice and as per a type of education complied with his/her personal preferences and abilities, as the right to education of minors is applied by their parents or legal guardians.

Within the national legislation preschool education is regulated as an integral part of the public education system. Pursuant to Art. 2 of PEA "The public education system includes kindergartens, schools and servicing units".

Art. 20, para. 2 of PEA reads as follows: *Preschool preparation of children two years before their admission to the first grade is obligatory, but not earlier than the year of the child's fifth birthday.* Through increasing the preparation for school from one to two years in 2010 the Bulgarian state assumes concrete commitments related to the early development of children and obliges to procure the necessary conditions for all 5-year-old children to attend a kindergarten – places at kindergartens /or at school, with provision of the necessary conditions/, aids free of charge, transport for children, charge payment reliefs, etc.

Which sectors/ agencies actively provide early preschool education and training and in what type of services? To what extent they supplement or overlap with each other? What are the successes in relation to guaranteeing access for all children? What are the obstacles? Which groups of children are exposed to the greatest risk of exclusion from early preschool education and training? What efforts are exerted in order to cover them?

Pursuant to PEA /Art. 18, para. 1/ kindergartens are for children from the age of 3 until their admission in the first school grade. In the Regulations on Implementation of the Public Education Act /RIPEA /, Art. 26, para. 1 specifies that kindergartens are preparatory institutions within the system of public education for supplying cares, training and education to children from the age of 3 until their admission to the first school grade.

RIPEA regulates the types of kindergartens - according to the specifics of organization of their activity and according to their financing, as follows:

Art. 27 specifies the types of kindergartens: full-day, half-day, weekly kindergartens /para. 1/ and special - for children with special educational needs and/or chronic diseases /para. 2/. At the kindergartens under para. 1 or at the schools there may also be organized half-day, preparatory or seasonal groups for children at preschool age.

The types of kindergartens according to their financing are regulated, respectively in Art. 10, Art. 11, Art. 16, Art. 19 and Art. 19a of RIPEA :

- Art. 10 sets forth that public kindergartens which are of national significance and are financed by the state budget are:
 - the kindergartens for educating, upbringing, and providing care only to children with special educational needs and/or chronic diseases, admitted after exhaustion of all other possibilities for integrated education and training and by wish submitted by the parents or legal guardians in writing to the principal of the kindergarten. They have available facilities providing conditions for cares, training and education of children from the whole country;
 - kindergartens for education, training and providing cares to children of military and civil officers working at the Ministry of Defense, Bulgarian Army and the structures subjected to the Minister of Defense and financed by the budget of the Ministry of Defense;
- Municipal kindergartens being of local significance, are financed out of the state budget and use real estate properties which are public municipal property, as these are regulated under Art. 11;
- Art. 16 specifies that private kindergartens ,which are opened or transformed following a request by Bulgarian natural persons or legal entities, are not financed out of the state or municipal budget and use their own or hired facilities;
- Bulgarian kindergartens with foreign participation, which are opened or transformed following a request by partnerships registered in the Republic of Bulgaria between Bulgarian and foreign natural persons and/or legal entities are not financed out of the state budget and use their own or hired facilities, as these are specified under Art. 19
- Art. 19a regulates foreign kindergartens, which are opened or transformed following a request by foreign legal entities in accordance with international treaties, are not financed out of the state budget and use their own or hired facilities.

Pursuant to Art. 20, para. 2 of PEA the mandatory preschool preparation of children is carried out in preparatory groups at kindergartens or preparatory groups at schools, as the parents and legal guardians do not pay any charge for the training.

In respect of the mandatory preschool preparation the problem with the educational infrastructure is solved by the formation of groups for preparation for school, which use the facilities of the schools.

Socially disadvantaged children, children speaking native tongue other than Bulgarian, children from the least accessible areas and children with special educational needs /including

children with disabilities/ are exposed to the greatest risk of exclusion from preschool education.

The Bulgarian state exerts efforts for the main initiatives in the field of preschool education to deliver results also for the poorest children and for children in the least accessible areas. For improving the access of children to obligatory preschool education pursuant to Art. 20, para. 3, i.5 and Art. 26, para. 3-6 of PEA of the children and students who are subject of obligatory preparation for school or obligatory education in a populated area in which there is no kindergarten or school, providing preschool preparation in the respective preparatory group or education in the respective grade, free of charge transport is provided to a kindergarten or a school in the nearest populated area on the territory of the municipality or in a neighboring municipality.

The Public Education Act contains texts guaranteeing equal access to education of children and students with disabilities: "Kindergartens are obliged to admit children with special educational needs and/or with chronic diseases /Art. 21, para. 2 of PEA/. Pursuant to Art. 27, para. 1 and 2 of PEA, children with special educational needs and/or with chronic diseases are educated in integrated manner at the schools. The schools are obliged to admit children with special educational needs and/or with chronic diseases.

Activities are performed also for supporting the early development of children and preschool training and preparation. Pursuant to Art. 20 para. 5 of PEA: «For children who do not have a good mastery of Bulgarian language, in addition to the obligatory preparation for school, Bulgarian language education is provided as well, based on specialized methodology for mastering Bulgarian language.»

The education in the obligatory preparatory groups is financially secured by the state. Apart from the funds allotted out of the state budget as per the unified cost standards for financing the alimony of a child, funds are annually provided also for learning aids to be used free of charge by the children in the preparatory groups.

As a result of the consistent policy for all-embracing and accessible education, the coverage of children in kindergartens in the period from school year 2000/2001 to school year 2013/2014. The values of the group net coefficient of enrollment of children from 3 to 6 years old¹ in preschool education per school years in the aforesaid period can be seen in Table 1.

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¹ The coefficient is calculated as a ratio between the number of preschool education trainees in the age group 3-6 years old to the number of population in the same age group.

Table 1. Group net coefficient of enrolment for preschool education in the period from the year 2000 to the year 2013²

School year	Group net coefficient of enrolment to preschool education
2000/2001	66,8 %
2001/2002	73,6 %
2002/2003	74,2 %
2003/2004	74,6 %
2004/2005	73,6 %
2005/2006	73,7 %
2006/2007	73,9 %
2007/2008	73,2 %
2008/2009	73,8 %
2009/2010	74,3 %
2010/2011	81,3 %
2011/2012	81,5 %
2012/2013	82,1 %
2013/2014	83,6 %

The dynamics of the values of the net coefficient of enrolment to preschool education in the period 2000- 2013 is visualized in Chart 1.

Chart 1. Dynamics of the values of the group net coefficient of enrolment to preschool education in the period 2000- 2013.

² Source : NSI



net coefficient of enrolment

During the period from school year 2000/2001 to school year 2013/2014, the net coefficient of enrolment to preschool education of children at the age of 3-6, increases its value from 66,8% /for the school year 2000/2001 / to 83,6% /for school year 2013/2014/.

Significant challenges to the overall coverage of children in kindergartens in recent years are based on problems with the infrastructure, especially in big cities (availability and efficiency of use).

The improvement of the scope of preschool education through increasing the number of kindergartens emerges as a key objective and investment priority also for the period until the year 2020.

What efforts are made for improving the quality of the various programmes for preschool training and preparation? What are the challenges? What good practices have been applied and have been successful for enhancing the quality of early preschool education and preparation?

What particular strategies and measures have been introduced in view of increasing the degree of preparation of the children before school among all children, and especially among those in underprivileged position? Does the state conduct any policies focused on the quality of public and private preschool training and preparation?

The assurance of quality and access to preschool training and preparation is a part of a number of strategic documents of the country –*National Programme for Reforms; Strategy for Life-Long Learning; Strategy for Decreasing the Share of Early School Leavers, as well as in the draft Strategy for Literacy Encouragement and Increasing.*

The extension of access to preschool preparation remains one of the main challenges in the field of education and provision of a smooth transition upon the admission to the first school grade. Bulgaria has determined as its national objective a 90 % share of the children included in preschool preparation. We accept this indicator as entirely quantitative and we consider that it does not take into account in any manner the measures of the Member States as regards raising the quality of the provided service.

In the year 2013 UNICEF with the support of the Ministry of Education and Science has conducted a *Study of the phenomena of non-coverage at school*, which also contains a short review of the role of preschool preparation. According to the results of the study some of the leading reasons for non-enrolment to preschool preparation are connected with:

- the existence of charges and other necessary (medical and administrative) expenses for enrolment in kindergartens of the children from families with limited financial abilities;
- areas with high concentration of vulnerable groups and small municipalities with limited funds for financing preschool preparation;
- isolated residential areas with prevailing Roma population, in many of which no kindergartens are available;
- the economic crisis exerts an overall impact on the demographic picture in the country;
- nevertheless, *increase* is observed in relation of the coverage of children included in preschool preparation;

The main measures, taken by the Ministry of Education and Science in respect of the specified challenges are:

- introduction of mandatory preschool preparation two years before the admission to the first school grade;
- elaboration of mechanisms for additional financing of the kindergartens and schools with preparatory groups;
- provision of additional Bulgarian language education for children with mother tongue other than Bulgarian;
- introduction of diagnostics for school preparedness;

Already in the year 2000 a state educational requirement is adopted for preschool training and preparation, whereby the preschool preparation syllabus is determined, presented through the achievable knowledge, skills and attitudes that are measured as a result of the education and training of the children at the kindergarten as per educational lines. The state educational requirement is updated in the year 2005. The preschool preparation syllabus is distributed in the following educational lines: Bulgarian language and literature, mathematics, natural

world, social world, game culture and recreation, art, music, constructive and technical and domestic activities and physical education.

In the year 2003 a programme for obligatory preparation of children for school is validated. Priority is given to the use of game forms and methods reflecting the specifics of the perception of children of preschool age.

Under National Programme *Caring for Every Student* module *Provision of additional education for children from the preparatory groups* additional education in Bulgarian language is provided. The value of the module is BGN 418 973. During the last year within the National Programme *Caring for Every Student*, module *Provision of additional education for children from the preparatory groups* 560 teachers and 3,392 children have been included. The project under Operational Programme Science and Education for Intelligent Growth the financing of several measures related to early preschool training is envisaged:

- ☐ implementation, application and assessment of the efficiency of standardized diagnostics for school preparedness;
- ☐ support to the pedagogic innovation whereby the chances of children and students for achievement of better education results are increased;
- ☐ provision of possibilities for education complied with the individual needs of children and students, stimulation of innovativeness and entrepreneurship;
- ☐ elaboration of programmes for family support for the purpose of encouraging the participation of parents in the educational process.

With the understanding that preschool preparation has the highest percentage of return on the process of life-long learning the Ministry of Education and Science drew up a draft of an act for amending and supplementing the Public Education Act, whereby it proposed that the preparation of children for school must be obligatory as of the year of the child's fifth birthday. The draft was accepted by the National Assembly and entered into force on 5 October 2010. In relation to the amendments, a term until the year 2012 was given to all municipalities for providing the obligatory preschool preparation.

Pursuant to the amendments to the Public Education Act the preparation of children for school two years before their admission to the first school grade is obligatory and is performed in preparatory groups at the kindergartens or schools, and for children who do not have a good mastery of Bulgarian language, apart from the obligatory preparation, additional education is provided for mastering Bulgarian language as well. The mastering of Bulgarian language by children for whom Bulgarian is not native tongue, is assessed as especially necessary in the period before their admission to the first school grade in order to reach a level of language mastery commensurate with that of the remaining children.

For the education and training of children in kindergartens programmes are elaborated in accordance with the state educational requirements regulated by Ordinance No. 4 of

18.09.2000 on preschool upbringing and preparation, issued by the Minister of education. The knowledge, skills and attitudes of the children as expected results from the education and training as per educational lines and age groups are particularized in the curriculums for preschool upbringing and preparation and with the curriculum for obligatory preparatory groups.

Objective 2: Universal primary basic education

Is the right of education embedded in the national constitution and legislation? Does the right of education guarantee free of charge, all-embracing education, at least for the basic level? Is the principle of non-discrimination applied within legislation and/or the policies in the sphere of education?

The laws in the Republic of Bulgaria guarantee equal treatment of citizens in respect of their right of education.

The right of education is regulated under Art. 53 of the Constitution of the Republic of Bulgaria.

Article 6 of the Public Education Act (PEA) states: «Education in state and municipal schools is free of charge.». The access to education in state and municipal school free of charge is regulated in RIPEA - Art. 5.

In Art. 4, para. 1 the Public Education Act recognizes the right of every citizen to receive education and guarantees its application without any discrimination /Art. 4, para. 2/. No restrictions or privileges, based on race, nationality, gender, ethnic and social origin, freedom of religion and social situation are allowed.

The Public Education Act (1991 and its subsequent amendments) provides for the inclusion in obligatory school education of children from 7 (optionally from 6) to 16 years of age.

The Regulations on Application of the Public Education Act /RIPEA / - Art. 8, para. 3 stipulate that students for whom Bulgarian is not a native tongue, may study their native tongue at the municipal schools in accordance with the state educational requirement for education level, general education minimum and syllabus.

The Discrimination Protection Act /Art. 4, para. 1/ does not allow unequal treatment of persons based on various characteristics, including disability.

Pursuant to Art. 17, i. 2 of the Act on Integration of Persons with Disabilities /AIPD/ the Ministry of Education and Science /MES/ provides a supportive environment for integrated education of children with disabilities.

The Public Education Act regulates the integrated education of children with special educational needs and/or with chronic diseases at schools. By exception only, when all other possibilities for education and training at state and municipal schools have been exhausted and upon declared wish in writing by the parents or legal guardians, the children with special educational needs and/or with chronic diseases can be admitted to special schools and servicing units /Art. 27, para. 4 of PEA/. The kindergartens are obliged to admit children with special education needs and chronic diseases /Art. 21, para. 2 of PEA/.

Pursuant to Art. 27, para. 1 and 2 of PEA children with special educational needs and/or chronic diseases shall study on integrated basis at schools.

Schools are obliged to admit children with special educational needs and/or chronic diseases.

A possibility is guaranteed for integrated education of children with sensory disorders, physical disorders, multiple disorders, mental disability, linguistic and speech disorders by way of creating supporting environment in kindergartens and schools in accordance with their health condition /§ 3a, i. 2 of the Additional Provisions of RIPEA /.

The accomplishment of the respective education level guarantees the mastering of a total educational minimum, as well as of knowledge and skills corresponding to the interests and individual abilities of students.

The general education minimum is the basis of the general education training. It includes obligatory knowledge and skills necessary for the successful fulfillment of students in the following level of education. The general educational minimum for the primary and pre-secondary stage of basic education is identical and obligatory for all types of schools.

The general educational training in our country is built on the principle of respecting:

fundamental human rights;
the rights of the child;
the traditions of Bulgarian culture and education;
the achievements of world culture;
the values of civil society;
freedom of conscience and freedom of thought.

The main objectives of general education training are:

1. to assist the physical and mental development of the student, for his/her successful orientation, adaptation and realization in society;
2. to create conditions for formation of value orientations related to the Bulgarian national identity, respect for other persons, empathy and civil responsibility;

3. to create conditions for development of needs, interests, and attitudes for learning and training and life-long self-perfection.

The general education training in Bulgarian school is implemented through the study of school subjects grouped in the following cultural and educational areas: Bulgarian language and literature; foreign languages; mathematics, informatics and information technologies; social studies, civil education and religions; natural sciences and ecology; arts; domestic activities and technologies; physical education and sports.

School education provides conditions for mastering literary Bulgarian language. The students for whom Bulgarian is not a native tongue, in addition to the obligatory study of Bulgarian language, are entitled to study their native tongue as well at the municipal school with the protection and control by the state.

The basic education has a duration of eight years and is carried out in two stages – primary (I-IV grade) and pre-secondary (V-VIII grade). It is acquired after completion of the lower secondary stage (VIII grade) and is testified by a certificate giving a right to study in the next education level, to vocational study, as well as to practice professions, for which basic education is required. Those who have completed the primary stage of basic education receive certificate for completed IV grade.

The primary stage of basic education guarantees the mastering of basic knowledge, skills and competencies, without which successful education at the pre-secondary level is impossible. The tasks of the study during this period are related to building initial literacy and building on it with skills which presuppose the mastering of both the functional and the key competencies necessary for realization in the modern democratic and knowledge-based society.

What particular policies and measures have been envisaged and introduced in view of removing the barriers which prevent children belonging to underprivileged groups from receiving access and successfully accomplish their basic education ?

The policy for all-embracing, accessible and quality education is designated for all children and students in the Republic of Bulgaria.

In the period 2000 - 2014 in Bulgarian educational system a number of achievements are observed, that contribute to overcoming the barriers to equal access to quality education of children from underprivileged groups.

In the Public Education Act, Art. 26, para. 3-6, it is specified that for children and students who are subject of obligatory training for school or obligatory education in a populated area in which no kindergartens or schools are available for providing preschool preparation in the relevant preparatory group or training for the relevant grade, free of charge

transport is provided to a kindergarten or school in the nearest populated area on the territory of the municipality or a neighboring municipality.

For students at the age of up to 16 in a populated area in which there is no school, free of charge transport is provided and/or boarding house at a central school in the nearest populated area on the territory of the municipality or a neighboring municipality when thereby the time for travel and/or expenses for this purpose are reduced.

For commuting students from I to VIII grade who study at central schools /PEA, Art. 26, para. 4/, full organization of the school day is provided as well as canteen meals, the financial means for which are determined in accordance with financial rules. Canteen meal provision is organized in accordance with the requirements set forth in ordinances issued by the Ministry of Health.

The funds for transport expenses, for organization of full school day and for canteen meals are provided on a target basis out of the central budget and/or European funds and programmes and are allotted on the grounds of rules validated by the Council of Ministers by way of ordinance for execution of the state budget.

Measures are elaborated for guaranteeing that all children from urban and rural regions are able to accomplish their education up to the age of 16.

The Additional Provisions of PEA /§ 6c., (1) § 6f., (1)/ regulate the establishment of *central and protected schools*.

"Central school" is a school located in the nearest populated area on the territory of the municipality, where training is provided to the students from the populated areas in which there is no relevant school.

"Protected school" is a school the closing down of which would distort the access to education in the area.

The policy of providing equal access to education for all children up to 18 years of age and until completion of secondary education is implemented also through granting scholarships to students after completion of basic education. Pursuant to Decree No 33 of the Council of Ministers of 15.02.2013 monthly scholarships shall be granted for achieved educational results, for supporting the access to education, for supporting students with permanent disabilities and students deprived of parental care.

One-off scholarships are also granted to a student for overcoming one-off social circumstances related to his/her access to education and for achieved high results in the study, out-of-class or out-of-school activity.

Apart from the funds provided by the state budget as per unified cost standards for financing the alimony of a child, in respect of a student funds are annually provided also for:

- textbooks and learning aids for gratuitous use by the children from the preparatory groups and the pupils from I to VII grade;
- transport for children and students up to 16 years of age;
- supporting the nutrition of children from the preparatory groups and the pupils from I to IV grade;
- full-school-day organization for the pupils in the primary level (the measure has started since school year 2010/2011 for grade I pupils, in the school year 2011/2012 grade II pupils are also included, in the school year 2012/2013 III grade pupils are included as well, and as of school year 2013/2014, IV grade pupils are included, as from the school 2014/2015 the inclusion of V grade students is also forthcoming);
- additional financing of protected schools;
- boarding houses for students from other populated areas;
- scholarships for students after completion of basic education .

The removal of the barriers preventing the integration of children from various underprivileged groups is an expression of the *targeted national policy for encouragement of inclusive education*.

Special focus in the training is placed on the encouragement of intercultural competences, democratic values and respect of fundamental rights, as well as the struggle against all forms of discrimination.

For tackling inequality at the primary level of basic education individual approach is ensured in the training of every child, and for the children who have difficulties in mastering the syllabus, additional training is provided. Through the National Programme *Caring for Every Student* annual ensuring of **additional training** is provided to pupils in the primary level of basic education for raising the level of their achievements in general education training. In school year 2013-2014 additional training has been provided to more than **4,000 pupils** at the primary stage of basic education, **2,919** out of whom have increased their assessment grades.

Special cares on the part of the state are taken for children with distinct natural gifts and talents. For provision of conditions for their participation in contests and students' Olympiads at municipal, regional, national and international level, scholarships are granted or additional financing to the schools through national programmes and projects.

An expression of the aspiration towards enhancing the quality of the education and training process while respecting the interests, abilities and age peculiarities of students is the policy for provision of **full school day organization**. As of the school year 2010-2011 full school day organization is being introduced on a stage-by-stage basis and up to date pupils from I to

IV grade are covered. By Decree No. 186 of the Council of Ministers of 2010 for provision of full school day organization to pupils from I to IV grades at the state and municipal schools additional funds are annually provided to all state and municipal schools for the pupils covered within the full school day organization. Through the National Programme *The School - Territory of the Students, Module on supporting full-day school for students in the initial school years Support to full day education of the pupils at the primary stage* additional conditions and prerequisites are created for mutual knowledge and communication of children from different communities. A great number of schools with full-day education process implement projects financed through the European Union funds (the project *Success*, for instance). Under the project *Enhancing the quality of education in central schools through the introduction of full-day organization*, financed under Operational Programme *Human Resource Development 2007-2013, Framework programme for full-day organization of the school process* is elaborated for stimulating the development of school programmes depending on the specifics of the school conditions and the particular needs. As a result of the implemented policy, the necessary conditions and high quality are ensured for its conducting.

What efforts (e.g., more inclusive social policies, stimuli, etc.) have been made in view of reducing the costs necessary for school enrolment and attendance?

In view of reducing the expenses necessary for school enrolment and attendance, the following policies have been implemented:

Provision of gratuitous use of sets of textbooks and learning aids:

Provided learning aids for children in preparatory group, of sets of textbooks and learning aids for pupils from I to IV grade, of sets of textbooks for the students from V to VII grade in the state, municipal and private kindergartens and schools.

Textbooks and learning aids, provided for gratuitous use, in special school subjects – Speech development and Pronunciation for students with impaired hearing ability

Textbooks and learning aids in the special school subjects for children and students with impaired hearing ability from the preparatory group to X grade

Organization and coordination of the activities for provision of transport free of charge for children and students up to the age of 16.

Optimized school network and improved coverage of students - National Programme School Network Optimization.

What policies and measures have been elaborated for the purpose of maximal retaining at school of children and adults dropping out at the primary level of basic education, as well as for the purpose of their passing to a higher educational level?

Measures are taken in order to prevent dropping out from school and early leaving of the educational system. Prevention aims at avoiding the emergence of prerequisites for dropping out from school and early school leaving, as well as limiting the conditions favoring these.

The policies and measures for prevention of dropping out from school and early school leaving encompass education and cares in early childhood age up to the completion of secondary education.

The reasons for early school leaving are economic, social, educational, ethno-cultural, institutional.

The PISA international study establishes that in Bulgaria there is a significant connection between the low educational results of children at school and the socioeconomic status of their families: on average, in Bulgaria 32% of the results' hesitations of the 15-year olds are explained by the socioeconomic and family environment of the student. For comparison, this share is about 22% in the states within the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development. As at the year 2009 approximately 26,000 children miss at least one school year since their parents do not enroll them in the first group at the kindergarten, others, about 20,000 children, are not enrolled in the second group of the kindergarten as well, and thus they lose two years of preschool preparation, and over 16,000 do not attend kindergarten altogether before the mandatory preparation for school.

One of the groups at risk of early school leaving is the group of children who are not included in the system of preschool education. Kindergarten nonattendance increases the risk of emergence of training difficulties at school, especially for children from vulnerable groups. These difficulties usually appear as early as at the initial level of education and can become a reason for early school leaving.

In the school year 2010/2011 mandatory two-year preparation before admission to the first school grade was introduced for 5-year-old children. Pursuant to Art. 20, para. 1 of PEA /in force since 05.10.2010/ *Preschool preparation of children two years before their admission to the first school grade is mandatory, but not earlier than the year of a child's fifth birthday.* This measure is also a preventive stage in relation to the decrease of uncovered and early school leavers.

As of the school year 2010/2011 the gradual introduction of full day school organization has begun, as at the school year 2013/2014 children from 1 to 4 school grade are

covered. Within this organization the obligatory school hours are combined with forms of self-preparation, interest-based activities and organized recreation. The purpose is to provide all children with better adaptation to school life, various possibilities for development, educational environment to help children in mastering knowledge, individual approach in training.

The project BG 051PO001-3.1.06 *Enhancing the quality of education in central schools through the introduction of full day organization of the study process* provides additional possibilities for the implementation of this organization. The full-day organization of the study process includes the complete educational cycle /mandatory training, obligatory - optional training, freely optional training, self-training, recreation and games, meals /for achievement of generally accessible, basic knowledge, based on the principles of justice, tolerance and viability.

Through inclusion of the students in activities under project BG051PO001-4.2.05-0001 *School for self-affirmation and preparation towards European horizons /USPEH/* conditions are created for providing sense to their free time. This is of special importance for students at risk of dropping out and/or students with displays of aggression and/or violence. The participation in extracurricular and out-of-school activities also leads to increasing the motivation of students to participate in the educational process, in accordance with their interests and needs.

The elaboration and application of overall, far-reaching and efficient policies for decreasing the vulnerability of risk groups is related to research, analysis and systematization of the specific reasons for early school leaving and (mapping) of the necessary measures for retaining students at school. It is necessary to ensure the provision of unified and reliable database and the implementation of policies at all levels – regional, municipal and school, and for guaranteeing of individual approach towards each particular case of early school leaving.

The Ministry of Education and Science implements national programmes, a part of which are focused on the prevention and restriction of early school leaving:

- **National Programme Creating an accessible architectural environment**, Modernization of school facilities /2014/ aims at improving social inclusion and provision of equal access to education of children and students with special educational needs through creating accessible architectural environment as part of the support needed for their general education training.

- **National programme for more complete coverage of the students /2007-2009/** has the objective of implementing strategic priorities related to a more complete coverage and retaining of students at mandatory school age.

Module *Provision of breakfast and/or fruit, and/or milk (tea) to students in I – IV school grade inclusive, and children in the preparatory groups and grades in schools and*

kindergartens aims at keeping children at school and supporting parents in the provision of meals to children.

Module *Provision of textbooks and learning aids for students from I to IV grade* aims at the provision of equal access to the syllabus for students at the state, municipal and private schools and of children from preparatory groups at kindergartens. The provision of textbooks and learning aids for gratuitous use is an investment that has a long-term effect on the access to and quality of education. The measure has a positive influence in respect of the difficulties of socially disadvantaged families in the provision of textbook and leads to reducing the dropping out of students from school.

Module *Provision of transport for students at the basic educational level* ensures conditions for equal access to education commensurate in quality through free of charge transport to the central schools for students, who study outside the populated area in which they live.

- **National Programme *For more complete coverage of the students at obligatory school age* /2010/** has the purpose of providing conditions for access to education of students at obligatory school age through carrying out activities related to the more complete coverage and retaining, irrespective of their ethnic belonging, gender, origin and religious affiliation and through creation of a possibility for everyone to study independently of his/her location and economic situation.

Under the module *Provision of additional training to students for raising the level of their achievements in general education preparation* from the National Programme *Caring for every student* additional training to students who have shown low results from the external assessment is provided.

- **National programme *At school without absences*** through the measure *Without absences* aims at reducing the share of absences through their correct recording in the school documentation, taking of real and efficient school measures for motivating students for regular attendance and active work in class and for attraction of parents as partners in the school life.

- **By the National Programme *School grid optimization*** conditions are created for guaranteeing access to education commensurate in terms of quality to every child and student and for development of a network of schools compatible with the interests and abilities of children and students.

As a preventive measure against dropping out from school of children from vulnerable ethnic communities, policies are implemented for overcoming the separating of children and students in groups /at kindergartens/ and classes /at schools/, for enhancing the intercultural competence of all participants in the educational process. Additional training in Bulgarian

language is provided, as parallel thereto a possibility is ensured for native tongue learning. Activities are introduced for increasing tolerance at schools and prevention of dropping out. The Centre for educational integration of children and students from ethnic minorities /CEICSEM/ finances projects for educational integration in pursuance of the objectives of the Strategy for educational integration of children and students from ethnic minorities.

By way of implementation of projects under Operational Programme *Human resource development 2007-2013* /OP HRD/ support is provided to the integration, decrease of the number of early school leavers, as well as the inclusion in the educational system of uncovered children from ethnic minorities.

Integration of children and students from ethnic minorities in the educational system is carried out through the activities under Project BG051PO001-4.1.03 ***Integration of children and students from ethnic minorities in the educational system under OP HRD***. The objective is via improving the conditions of equal access to education and training and strengthening the motivation for inclusion in the educational process to create conditions for more successful social and employment realization of children and students from ethnic minorities who are excluded or are at risk of exclusion.

Through Project BG051PO001-4.1.05 ***Educational integration of children and students from ethnic minorities under OP HRD*** activities are carried out for improvement of the conditions for equal access to education and training, strengthening the motivation for participation in the educational process and additional activities with children and students for whom Bulgarian language is not a native tongue.

The objective of Operation BG051PO001-4.1.06 ***Reintegration of dropped-out pupils in the educational system under OP HRD*** is implementation of activities for reintegration of pupils who have already dropped from of the educational system and prevention of their repeated dropping-out.

Under projects implemented by CEICSEM and projects under OP HRD trainings of teachers are conducted for improving their skills for work in multicultural educational environment. Various forms of work are performed with the parents of children and students from vulnerable ethnic communities and groups for creation of positive attitude to education.

The Ministry of Education and Science, jointly with the Regional Education Inspectorates and with the municipalities, exercises control over the receiving kindergartens and schools for non-admission of ethnically separated groups and classes.

In 2013 a **Strategy** is adopted **for decreasing the share of early school leavers /2013-2020/**. The strategy builds on the policies and measures being implemented for overcoming early school leaving and unifies and synchronizes the efforts of institutions in an overall integrated approach for addressing the challenges related to this phenomenon.

The strategy systematizes the specific reasons for dropping out from school and early school leaving and sets forth policies and measures for prevention, intervention and compensation of the early leaving of the educational system. Special attention is devoted to the policies for access to education and enhancing the quality of education for children and students from vulnerable ethnic communities, as well as those with special educational needs. It is envisaged to elaborate and implement a Coordination mechanism for improving the control over all sector policies related to ensuring the coverage and retaining of children and students at school until completion of their education.

The number of students and those who have left the educational system per school years during the period from school year 2000/2001 to school year 2013/2014 is presented in Table 2.

Table 2. Students and persons who have left the educational system per school years during the period from school year 2000/2001 to school year 2013/2014

Age (in comple ted years)	2000 /01	2001 /02	2002 /03	2003 /04	2004 /05	2005 /06	2006 /07	2007 /08	2008 /09	2009 /10	2010 /11	2011 /12	2012 /13	2013 /14
Total	200 449	199 206	201 317	201 145	202 803	206 243	206 745	207 682	212 454	217 804	223 186	227 971	235 015	240 622
Under 3	9 259	11 485	11 172	10 263	8 731	7 940	8 404	8 738	9 131	8 496	7 375	7 254	6 632	6 165
3	37 088	39 563	43 514	42 123	39 298	40 435	42 421	44 758	47 102	48 215	49 391	50 844	52 919	51 135
4	47 207	44 187	46 563	49 413	48 724	46 046	47 162	48 248	50 050	51 998	52 696	53 899	55 840	58 540
5	49 850	51 235	47 411	48 485	52 935	52 234	49 645	50 527	50 946	52 882	56 282	58 284	60 725	64 317
6	55 169	51 048	51 394	49 965	52 467	58 945	58 490	54 725	54 396	55 440	56 709	57 000	58 264	59 886
7	1 797	1 559	1 099	823	606	555	591	638	782	689	694	659	585	561
Over 7	79	129	164	73	42	88	32	48	47	84	39	31	50	18
Boys	103 507	102 749	104 148	103 910	104 669	106 299	106 911	107 452	109 789	112 711	115 267	117 804	121 253	123 947
Under 3	4 678	5 752	5 663	5 270	4 473	3 989	4 294	4 487	4 654	4 343	3 685	3 705	3 323	3 162
3	19 270	20 247	22 290	21 580	20 322	20 865	21 863	23 004	24 333	24 884	25 469	26 293	27 104	26 238
4	24 387	22 944	24 103	25 456	25 242	23 764	24 488	24 928	25 804	26 949	27 270	27 789	28 844	29 930
5	25 717	26 475	24 699	25 058	27 181	26 940	25 658	26 191	26 212	27 336	29 047	30 057	31 347	33 160
6	28 441	26 429	26 713	26 025	27 067	30 400	30 253	28 442	28 292	28 753	29 372	29 555	30 270	31 142

7	971	841	590	484	358	302	340	369	459	397	397	388	340	307
Over 7	43	61	90	37	26	39	15	31	35	49	27	17	25	8
Girls	96	96	97	97	98	99	99	100	102	105	107	110	113	116
	942	457	169	235	134	944	834	230	665	093	919	167	762	675
Under 3	4	5	5	4	4	3	4	4	4	4	3	3	3	3
	581	733	509	993	258	951	110	251	477	153	690	549	309	003
3	17	19	21	20	18	19	20	21	22	23	23	24	25	24
	818	316	224	543	976	570	558	754	769	331	922	551	815	897
4	22	21	22	23	23	22	22	23	24	25	25	26	26	28
	820	243	460	957	482	282	674	320	246	049	426	110	996	610
5	24	24	22	23	25	25	23	24	24	25	27	28	29	31
	133	760	712	427	754	294	987	336	734	546	235	227	378	157
6	26	24	24	23	25	28	28	26	26	26	27	27	27	28
	728	619	681	940	400	545	237	283	104	687	337	445	994	744
7	826	718	509	339	248	253	251	269	323	292	297	271	245	254
Over 7	36	68	74	36	16	49	17	17	12	35	12	14	25	10

Chart 1 illustrates the dynamics in the number of those who have left the educational system per school years during the period from school year 2000/2001 to school year 2013/2014.

Chart 2. Dynamics in the number of those who have left the educational system per school years during the period from school year 2000/2001 to school year 2013/2014.



During the period from school year 2000/ 2001 to school year 2013/ 2014 the number of those who have left the educational system changes dynamically, as the trend of decrease is preserved relatively stable in the period from school year 2006/ 2007 to school year 2013/ 2014.

According to Eurostat data in 2013 the share of persons at the age of 18-24, who have left the educational system early is 12.4%. A minimum decrease is observed as compared to the year 2012, when their share equals 12.5%. Bulgaria stays close to the average value of the indicator for the 28 EU member states, which is 12%. Nevertheless, again after the year 2010, Bulgaria marks a value above the average for EU-28.

Objective 3: Meeting the educational needs of adolescents and adults

**Which are the most frequently articulated needs among the young and adult students?
How are they satisfied?**

Adolescence is a key period of development and education during this period is very important because it is related to the acquiring of functional competence, guaranteeing the creation of fundamentals for successful coping in various social environment – at home, at school, within a professional community.

The acquisition of functional competence during the pre-secondary and secondary stage must be a commitment not only for the teachers in Bulgarian language and literature, but also for the teachers in all subjects of study. Reading and listening of texts, speaking and

writing should be in the focus of attention during every school hour, as for that purpose the curriculum standards and syllabuses are optimized and all teachers are subjected to qualification in the acquisition of the relevant skills.

The teachers in all subjects of study must rethink the approaches, means and methods of education. **The communication approach of study** must become a leading one not only in Bulgarian language and literature and the teacher works in such a manner that is harmonious with the modern understanding of literacy in general and of reading literacy in particular. The text must turn into an object, immersed in a real-life context, and the tasks thereon must presuppose an assessment to what degree adolescents are able to cope in real-life situations.

The mastering of curricula must be facilitated and enriched through the provision of varied, attractive, close to the world perception of modern adolescents print and electronic materials. Thus students will be motivated and involved in the process of study, on the one hand, and on the other, the acquisition of the specific knowledge and skills for work with various types of texts will occur with the means of modern technologies. The coordination of the separate initiatives directed at the stimulation of reading at national, regional and local level is also assisted by the possibilities of electronic educational portals in which information sources for various age groups are concentrated. Their role is tremendously favorable for exchange of good initiatives and school practices.

The integration of information technologies in the educational process requires the use of new software solutions with distinct educational value.

The continuity between the primary and pre-secondary level creates conditions for successful adaptation of adolescents and for easier overcoming of changes in respect of teachers, school subjects, requirements, the expectations from them. All this could be achieved only given the close interaction between the teachers from the two levels in organizational and methodical aspect, especially in grade V. Well considered and targeted work is necessary at pre-secondary level for development of the skills which have not been perfected yet. The overcoming of the erroneous belief that the literacy of students must be accomplished until the end of the primary level presupposes the application of individual approach of pre-secondary teachers to each individual adolescent.

The periodically conducted standardized external and internal evaluation must provide a clear picture of the students' achievements and of the needs of optimization of the educational methods, of updating the educational environment. The evaluation is to be complied with the specifics of the particular subject of study and of the class, and with the results expected at the end of each level on the one hand, and on the other, with the established international assessment.

The cooperation between the school and the employers should be guided by the necessity of creation of lasting beliefs in students that literacy level is directly related to their successful

social and professional fulfillment. The encouragement of literacy by the prospective employers as well will be one of the stimuli for more active and responsible attitude towards the acquisition of functional and complex literacy.

It is universally known that family environment is of exceptional significance for the development of the adolescents' potential. That is why the school must lend a helping hand to the parents and their attracting to the learning process and for increasing the functional literacy of their children. It is necessary to shift the attention of parents – from **what is being learnt** to **how it is learnt** and **what is achieved**, i.e., to stimulate parental interest in the expected learning results.

Despite the globally increasing unemployment due to a lack of modern working skills in a significant part of the population, the participation of illiterate and low-literate adults in learning is still unsatisfactory. They often have problems with basic skills that are of key importance for successful integration in societies nowadays. That is why of paramount importance is the provision of access to high quality and accessible **literacy provision courses** for adults and of appropriate environment for compensation of literacy problems - on the workplace and beyond it.

For potential adult learners the available learning experience is rather different. For some it is altogether missing and that is why their education must start with mastering the mechanisms of reading and writing and with arithmetic algorithms. For others who have left school early and have lost their skills of reading, writing and arithmetic, it must be recovered and built-on. The specifics of the process of literacy provision to adults presupposes **the use of forms, methods and means different from those used for providing literacy to children**. It presupposes special attention to the selection of curriculum and on the assessment methods in order to take into account the available individual life or professional experience of the learners and to support their motivation for life-long learning.

The concept of *adult literacy provision*, apart from the requirements for reading, writing and arithmetic, includes competences necessary for the realization of modern man. In this meaning linguistic literacy is to be tied to the development of skills in the field of ICT and to presuppose the use of new technologies in adult education.

The elaboration and implementation of appropriate policies for stimulation of literacy among adults requires **the collection and use of data** at school, regional and national level which allow researching the needs of provision of literacy to adults and the possibilities for their fulfillment.

On the methodic preparation and on the adequate impact of the teacher is to depend the overcoming of the weaknesses related to the psychological and didactic aspects of the process of literacy provision to adults. On his/her skill to implement pedagogical technologies

adequate in respect of the experience of the adult learners is to depend the result of the literacy provision.

Adult learners apply targeted efforts to study when they have realized for themselves the benefit thereof. That is why the conducting of **information campaigns** for inclusion of illiterate and low literate persons in training shall be based on taking into consideration and recognizing their experience and their values as a part of the knowledge being significant to them as well as of their orientation towards learning as "orientation towards life." The overcoming of stereotypes and prejudices of ethno-cultural environment implies their good knowing and continuous communication between the school community and the learner, including via mediator.

For raising the self-esteem and motivation of adults to learn and for increasing their literacy of substantial importance is the development of the system for **recognition and validation of informal and non-formal learning**. The change of the status of the adult learner and his/her return to the "literacy" cause presupposes broader possibilities for offering forms of education, which correspond to the interests and abilities of employed persons – evening classes, distance learning, etc.

Objective 4: Adult literacy and continuing education

Is the right of literacy embedded in the national legislation? Are there any existing national laws, policies and/or plans for eradication of illiteracy?

Legislation:

The right of education and continuous participation of adults in the processes of Life-Long Learning (LLL) and respectively, the right of literacy provision, is regulated by Art. 4, para. 1 and para. 2 of the Public Education Act, stating that *Citizens are entitled to education. They can continuously improve their education and qualification and that No restrictions and privileges shall be allowed on the grounds of race, nationality, gender, ethnical and social origin, religious freedom and social situation.*

The right of access to an educational institution, respectively the right of access to literacy provision is regulated under Art. 9, para. 1 of the Public Education Act, which sets forth that *Every citizen shall exercise his/her right of education at a school of his/her choice and a type of training in accordance with their personal preferences and abilities.*

Policies and plans:

Policies in the field of LLL are regulated by the adopted in the year 2013 **National strategy for life-long learning for the period 2014 – 2020.**

In accordance with the embedded in the Strategy, Action Plan for 2014 is adopted in pursuance of the *National strategy for life-long learning for the period 2014 – 2020*.

In the plan a number of measures are contemplated for reduction of illiteracy among the population in the country, which are examined in sub-item 4.

By Decree of the Council of Ministers of 22 October 2014 **National strategy for encouragement and increasing of literacy 2014 – 2020** was adopted.

The Strategy presents an analysis of the factors and trends for development of literacy, provides a definition for the various types of literacy and clarifies the scope and content of the very concept of "literacy".

Depending on the functions, objectives and age groups to which they relate, for the purposes of the Strategy the following types of literacy are distinguished:

- **basic literacy**– a skill for reading and understanding of a text, for writing and proper use of the language in a particular context (related to the competences which students are expected to possess at the end of grade IV);
- **functional literacy**– skill for discovering, selecting, extracting and synthesizing of information from various sources and for its use for achievement of a particular goal both in learning of all subjects of study and in various real-life situations (it is related to the competences which the students are expected to possess at the end of their basic education)
- **multifunctional literacy**– competence for creation, understanding, interpretation and critical assessment of written information (it is related to competences expected to be developed and demonstrated by the persons within their training for acquisition of secondary education and of higher education degree).

According to the text of the Strategy literacy **reflects the civil and cultural competencies of the personality** and therefore in the different periods of achieving personal maturity specific objectives and tasks emerge for education and training.

Even though the outlined specific focus of the Strategy is on the achievement of functional literacy, the specific policies presuppose stage-by-stage building of basic literacy and building on it until attaining multifunctional literacy.

As at the time of elaboration of the Strategy, no generally accepted concept of literacy exists in Bulgaria. The traditional understanding of literacy is most often related to mastering reading and writing in the native tongue (or in the language that is official for the particular country in which the person lives).

At the same time, due to the lack of another word in Bulgarian, the same word "literacy" is used in the meaning of both linguistic literacy (literacy) and of mathematical

literacy (numeracy), and often of literacy in the field of natural sciences and technologies. In this manner literacy functions in a narrow (understood exactly as reading and writing, i.e., mostly to indicate "reading literacy" and/or language literacy) and in a broad sense (understood as a complex of "literacies", including mathematical, financial, numerical, in the area of natural sciences and technologies, and often it is perceived as a synonym of competences). For the purposes of this Strategy the concept of **literacy** will be used to indicate **linguistic literacy in the official language**, the underlying element of which is mostly the reading literacy (related to the skills of reading and writing), but it is consistently related to the remaining skills as well - listening and speaking.

In the document of the National strategy for encouragement and increasing of literacy 2014-2020 a review is presented of the steps taken internationally for unified defining of the concept of *literacy*. The strategy expressly refers to the definition of literacy adopted by UNESCO in 2003 at an international expert meeting: " *Literacy is the ability to identify, understand, interpret, create, communicate and compute, using printed and written materials associated with varying contexts. Literacy involves a continuum of learning in enabling individuals to achieve their goals, to develop their knowledge and potential, and to participate fully in their community and wider society.* "

The National strategy defines primary literacy in the following manner: *Primary literacy* is related to the initial stage of mastering reading and writing along with the understanding what is being read and written, whereby the code for transition from graphic signs to the sound form of the word in reading and vice versa – from the sound form to the graphic one in writing (*primary provision of literacy*). The components of **primary literacy** include the skill to read, the skill to write and the skill to understand the meaning of what is being read and written – skills which should be acquired **in the first grade** in accordance with the requirements embedded in the national curricula. It is expressly stated that the lack of primary literacy provides grounds for determining a person as *illiterate*.

This concept is also the closest to the one used by the National Statistical Institute in the performance of population censuses, as by this is meant a person not able to read and understand the meaning of what is written and is not able to write a short statement about his/her everyday activities. A person who is able to read and write only numbers and his/her own name, must be regarded as illiterate. Likewise, illiterate is a person who can read, but cannot write and a person who can read and write only a few memorized ritual phrases.

In difference of primary literacy, *secondary literacy* is usually related to the rapidly developing technologies and the skills to practise a particular profession. The overcoming of secondary illiteracy requires continuous learning, education and qualification, because the introduction of new technologies in the employment sphere threatens the working adults to lose their chances for successful social and personal fulfillment.

Basic literacy and *necessary literacy*- the former is understood as a minimum level sufficient for independent reading for the purpose of self-education and the latter is related to a level dependant on the social context of a particular country and changing in time depending on the modifications in the specific social situation.

Inasmuch **basic literacy** as a rule is related to basic skills of reading and understanding of text, as well as writing and proper use of the language in accordance with the literary language norms (research of the acquisition of these skills is performed by the international research PIRLS), this type of literacy can be correlated to the skills, which the students are expected to acquire **at the end of the initial stage** of basic education in accordance with the state educational standards. To a certain extent and with the explicit specification of the difference in the targets, focus and scope of notions, these are also the skills demonstrated by the persons who reach level 1 in the Programme for International Student Assessment PISA, as well as the persons who reach level 1 in the Programme for International Assessment of Adult Competencies PIAAC (Appendix No. 2).

During the 1950s in relation to the idea of eliminating illiteracy among adult population in the world *functional literacy* becomes a topic of discussion. According to the definition of UNESCO *functionally literate is a person who can participate in activities in which literacy is a condition for efficient functioning of his/her group and community and which enables him/her to use reading, writing and arithmetic for his/her self-perfection and for the community's development.*

Functional literacy can be viewed in two dimensions: as *application of the knowledge of reading, writing (and arithmetic) in everyday life*, for performance of tasks that are various in nature (for instance, reading of inscriptions on buildings or goods, orientation in the timetable of transport vehicle as to the time and place wherefrom it departs, etc.); as availability of *necessary knowledge and skills for practicing certain functions*, among which the most important is the function of a working person.

The concept of PISA about *functional literacy* in the field of reading is based on the understanding that this is the skill to *understand, realize and use written texts for achievement of concrete targets, for developing the potential of a personality and for its full participation in social life*, i.e., functional literacy is present when reading and writing are mastered as distinct practices with motivation for use and are thus integrated in the social behavior of the person in various spheres. In other words, functional literacy is interpreted in a much wider context than the skill to read and write.

Correlated to the state educational requirements and national curricula in Bulgaria, the basis for acquisition of *functional literacy* is laid in the primary school, it is built on a stage-by-stage basis within the pre-secondary stage, as the elements of functional literacy in the

field of reading are derived as expected results from the education **at the end of basic education**, and every student is expected to possess it before the end of his/her mandatory education.

To the extent to which the Strategy for encouragement and increasing literacy is related to the encouragement and development of literacy in the field of reading, under the concept of *functional literacy*, the Strategy understand by default the ability of a person to ***discover, select, extract, analyze and synthesize information from sources different in nature and to use it for creation of a text depending on the specific context for the achievement of a given purpose.***

What can explain the changes in literacy of adults and adolescents in the country since the year 2000? Which are the positive factors and obstacles to the achievement of this objective of education for all for improving literacy of adults by 50%?

Dynamics per years:

During the past ten years the educational structure of the population in the country has significantly improved, as the share of persons at the age of 25-64 with basic and lower education has increased from 28.4% in 2004 to 22.5% in 2008 and to 18.2% in 2013, as this is a value that is by 6.6 percent points lower than the average value in the EU(28), and the improvement for the last 10 years is by more than 10 percent points.

Even though the data for the past 10 years indicate improvement in the educational structure, an increase of the relative share of illiterate persons among the younger generations. The share of illiterates among the persons above 15-29 of age is 2.18%, while in the persons above the age of 30-64 it is 1.14%, and in persons older than 65 the share is 2.48%. Especially alarming is the share of illiterate persons among those of age 20-29– 2.27%; it is striking that these are the generations which should have, on a mandatory basis, (for Bulgaria the period of mandatory education is from 7 to 16 years old) been encompassed by the educational system during the period between 1989 and 2007 and these are years in which the educational system in Bulgaria is accompanied by a number of restrictions including both the reduction of funds and closing down of a number of schools. Among young people at the age of 12-14 the share of illiterate persons is barely 1.59%, which clearly shows that the measures for access improvement taken in recent years are effective.

Which are the persons remaining illiterate? Where are they? How can they be covered via relevant literacy programmes with good quality?

Localization of illiterate persons:

According to data of the National Statistical Institute (NSI) the share of illiterate persons in Bulgaria at the age of 9+ is 1.67%, and in the group of 25-64 year-olds it is 1.27%, which is a little below 123,000 for the first group and accordingly, almost 60,000 for the persons at the age of 25-64.

The distribution of persons at the age of 7+ completed years who have never attended school shows that their share is the greatest in the regions of Kardzhali (3.56%), Sliven (3.53%), Silistra (2.54%), Dobrich (2.09%) and Yambol (2.00%). A more in-depth review of two of the five regions shows that these are among the regions with the lowest levels of employment among the population at the age 15-64: Sliven (48.5%) and Silistra (42.4%), occupy the 24th and 28th place as per employment level for the year 2013 (out of 28 regional centers), the remaining three regions still occupy 8th, 9th and accordingly, 10th place. Another specific characteristic of the regions is the presence of compact ethnic masses. In the region of Kardzhali the share of ethnic groups other than Bulgarian is 69.8%, in Silistra it is 42.6%, and in Sliven it is 23.4%, which is rather higher than the average value for the country, equaling 14.6%.

Illiteracy viewed within the ethnic group itself (age group 25 to 64 years old) shows that the share of illiterate persons is the highest among the Roma ethnos – 16.6% out of all self-declared Roma persons have stated that they are illiterate according to the UN definition, among the Turkish such are 2.8%, and among Bulgarians these are barely 0.4%. What is striking is also the high relative share of illiterate persons among Roma people at the age of 20-24 and 25-29, accordingly, 20.2% and 21.4%.

What type of programmes for continuous/basic – UNESCO's note basic/ primary education have been organized in the country for provision of literacy to adults? How can they become even more efficient?

Specific programmes:

Within the project **Development and extension of the system for provision of literacy to adults in order to ensure access to the labour market** it is envisaged for a little more than 3.4 K persons over the age of 16 to pass courses for literacy provision (including for studying the syllabus for Vth, VIth and VIIth grade), as in this manner the persons who have passed literacy provisions courses in the period 2012-2014 will reach 14,365. The data as at 15.04.2014 show that 5,430 persons have declared their wish to proceed to the next level. The persons encompass 83 schools in 24 from the 28th regional centers in the country. The distribution of those who have declared their wish for participation shows that approximately 44% of them will take part in a literacy provision course, 20% will study the syllabus in the V grade, 24% in the VIth grade and almost 12 in the VII grade.

In performance of the objectives set for the year 2014 it is expected for the total accumulated (for the last 3 years) contribution of the project, for reduction of illiteracy among persons at the age of 16+ completed years to reach and even exceed a value of the order 9-13%³ as compared to the population (of illiterate persons), recorded in Census 2011.

In 2014 the Ministry of Labour and Social Policy (MLSP) has also performed activities related to the **project *Training for literacy provision*** for illiterate and low-literate persons registered at the employment services at the Employment Agency (EA), as it is envisaged for 2,000 persons to pass literacy provision courses, motivation training, training for acquisition of key competencies and professional qualification. It is counted that this measure will contribute to raising the share of those employed among the persons who have completed lower than secondary education.

In relation to the weak results of a large part of Bulgarian students in a study of functional literacy within the study of OECD a number of initiatives are applied in relation to stimulation of reading among children.

Increasing efficiency:

Deficits are recorded in the full communication between the stakeholders, as it is necessary for the efforts of different institutions to be united in order to attain a sustainable result.

The Ministry of Education and Science was a beneficiary under the project *New Chance for Success*, a scheme for direct provision of grant BG051PO001- 4.3-01. *Provision of Literacy to Adults*.

In performance of the project activities, an overall model for training of adults is elaborated and applied in practice, as it includes elaboration of an overall methodology for conducting the training (training schemes, curricula, methodical and learning packages), realization of the training, conducting of tests and certification of the achieved results.

Under the project training is conducted in courses for literacy provision and in courses for mastering the syllabus envisaged for pre-secondary level grades of basic education. The number of persons included in training for completion of primary level and grades from the secondary level as at September 2014 is 16,386.

The trainings are conducted under curricula and syllabuses elaborated specially for the conducted courses and validated by the project manager.

³ The calculation is an approximation, in which as denominator is used the total number of illiterate persons determined as such in accordance with the UN definition (353), and as nominator is used the number of the persons who have completed literacy provision programmes, revised in accordance with the number of persons who have taken part in more than one literacy provision programme through the use of the proportion 2/5.

What direction should be followed in future in order to develop programmes for literacy provision and continuing primary/basic – UNESCO's note/ education for adults and youths?

In future the literacy provision programmes should not be viewed as a problem and function of the educational system only. The future development of literacy provision programmes requires focusing the efforts for literacy provision in order to achieve a certain basic literacy related to the acquisition of educational degree and professional qualification for ensuring employment.

In fact, low literacy is a problem of society with enormous consequences for the ambitions and strategies in the area of public healthcare, employment, participation in digitization, e-government, civic participation, poverty and social involvement and integration.

Objective 5: Gender equality

Are there any policies, strategies, plans, mechanisms and legislation in place against discrimination in education, which put a special emphasis on gender equality? What authorities and/or rights are granted to girls and women under the national legislation in the area of education?

What inequalities exist in the area of education in your country? At what level and in what type of education ? To what extent? In what manner they affect the progress of the achievement of the Objectives of Education for All?

To what extent the efficiently existing policies, strategies, plans and mechanisms encourage/guarantee gender equality in education? What are the main hurdles/obstacles to the encouragement/guaranteeing of gender equality in and through education ? How do you cope with them?

What are the programmes and policies encouraging the participation of girls (or boys) at school? What strategies have been applied for the purpose of maximum retention of girls (or boys) at school, as well as for the conducting of a smooth transition from primary education to pre-secondary and secondary level of education?

What are the policies and programmes for encouraging the participation of women (or men) in programmes for literacy provision to adults, as well as in programmes for primary/basic - UNESCO's note/ education ? What strategies have been applied and implemented in view of the maximum retention of women (or men) in the programmes for literacy provision to adults, as well as in the primary/basic - UNESCO's note/ education?

Under the ***Protection Against Discrimination Act*** (effective as of 01.01.2004), Section II of Chapter II (Protection against Discrimination) is under the title *Protection in exercising the right of education and training*. Art. 35 of the specified act is oriented directly towards gender equality.

Pursuant to this Article the persons who perform the education and training activities, as well as those who draw up textbooks and learning aids *are obliged to provide information and to apply methods of education and training in a manner directed towards overcoming the stereotypes about the role of a woman and a man in all spheres of social and family life*. Furthermore, kindergartens, schools and higher education establishments are required to include in their educational curricula and plans a training on the issues of equality between women and men.

There are no special strategies for gender equality in education in place, or authorities and/or rights for girls and women in the area of education. Equal access of genders to education is traditionally guaranteed and does not constitute a significant problem of society.

As a more significant problem is perceived the issue of access to education of children with special educational needs. In that regard, by virtue of order of the Minister of education and science, in the year 2013, an inter-departmental working group is formed with the task to elaborate a draft concept for changes in the regulatory basis in relation to the application of Art. 24 *Education* of the Convention on the Rights of Persons with Disabilities. Such concept is elaborated also in respect of the application of Art. 21 *Freedom of expression, freedom of opinion and access to information*.

Objective 6: Quality of education

Is *quality* regarded as a part of the right of education embedded in the national legislation in the sphere of education? In what manner is quality defined in the national legislation in the area of education, as well as in the policies and programmes?

What is meant by *quality of education* in the country? Which aspects and what indicators and standards are used in the country for measuring the status of the education quality?

What specific policies and measures are introduced for additional improvement of education quality? To what extent are they efficiently based on experience? What other policies and measures are necessary?

What is the experience of the country in respect of the impact of the separate actions taken by the state for improving quality (teachers, textbooks, school environment, instructing and learning methodologies, support service, etc.), as well as for improvement of the learning results?

In what manner the successful measures for improving quality can be introduced also at schools and for students in underprivileged situation?

How can the educational results from the viewpoint of literacy, arithmetic and competence for life can be guaranteed and measured more accurately?

The assurance and improvement of the quality of education is embedded in all regulatory deeds, even when it is not explicitly expressed. All measures than have been taken as well as completed activities are proofs thereof.

In the year 2000 state educational requirements (SER) were elaborated in respect of the syllabus for the respective educational levels and degrees in all subjects of study within the mandatory general education training. The requirements are adopted by Ordinance No. 2 on syllabi of 18.05.2000 and by Ordinance No. 4 on preschool training and preparation of 18.09.2000. Art. 3 of Ordinance No. 2 determines that the requirements for syllabi include general and specific key groups of skills, integral and interdisciplinary areas of the syllabus material depending on the specifics of the school subjects and on the cultural and educational areas. Based on the validated state educational requirements for syllabi, curricula were elaborated for all subjects of study for each grade of the school education. The curricula's underlying concept is personal development of students and no discrimination is allowed on any grounds.

In the year 2008 a campaign was conducted for promotion of the key competencies embedded in the European Reference Framework on Key Competences passed by the European Parliament on 18 December 2006.

National external assessment has been introduced in order to measure the results achieved according to the respective level of state educational requirements for syllabi. Its stage-by-stage conducting has commenced since the school year 2006-2007 when it took place for the first time for the students of the IV grade on four basic school subjects, namely, Bulgarian language and literature, Mathematics, Man and nature, Man and society. As of the school year 2009-2010 it is applied also for students in the VII grade on the following subjects of study: Bulgarian language and literature, Mathematics, Cultural Education Area Natural Sciences and Ecology, Cultural Education Area Social Sciences, Civil Education and Religion; English language, Spanish language, Italian language, German language, Russian language and French language (depending on the foreign language being learnt by the students). Traditionally, for more than ten years external assessment is also conducted in foreign languages for the students of VIII grade with intensive foreign language learning.

In the school year 2008-2009 the first **state matriculation exams based on the State Educational Requirements adopted in 2000**. The state matriculation exams measure the achieved results, which include knowledge, skills, attitudes or competences, from the

education in the relevant subject of study or cycle of subjects of study within the mandatory training at the secondary level, irrespective of the duration of the level and the planned hours of study for the respective subject of study or cycle of subjects of study. These are two, as one of them is in Bulgarian language and literature, and the second is determined by choice of the student among the subjects of study: "foreign language", "mathematics", "physics and astronomy", "biology and health education", "chemistry and environment protection", "history and civilization" and "geography and economy" and the cycle of subjects titled "philosophy" studied in the mandatory general education classes. Based on his/her own wish, the student may also pass state matriculation exams in selected by him/her subjects of study or cycle of subjects.

The National Strategy for Life-Long Learning sets forth as main challenge the organizing and orienting of education and training towards the acquisition of key competences by all learners. For the attainment of this goal and for its transformation into a foundation of the educational process it is necessary to devote more attention to the mastering of the basic skills which are to evolve in sustainably acquired competences, such as competences in the field of native tongue for the achievement of functional literacy, literacy in the field of mathematics and natural science, technological and digital literacy, as well as the skills for communication in a foreign language. At the same time, higher quality of teaching must be ensured, an important condition for which is the necessity of efficient basic qualification as well as continuous qualification of teachers and lecturers.

An important prerequisite is also the transformation of the profession of the teacher and lecturer in an attractive career choice through all expedient means and mechanisms.

It is necessary to improve the management of education and training institutions and elaborate efficient and flexible systems for quality assurance. Of substantial significance is the improvement of the system for financing as an instrument for guaranteeing the efficiency of primary and continuous education and training via shared and balanced responsibility between the state, the employers and the students.

The National Programme System for National Standardized External Assessment has the objective of guaranteeing equal access and of quality education for children, through the provision of conditions for development of the school education system. One of the most important among them is the functioning of a modern, efficient and objective system for control and assessment of the quality of the results achieved in the educational process. In order to improve the effective, but not sufficiently efficient system for internal assessment, the traditional and not sufficiently efficient methods for checking and assessment of the skills and knowledge must be overcome, as they presuppose memorization on the part of the student and the influence of subjective factors in the assessment on the part of the teacher. The performance of external assessment gives a possibility for objective assessment of the results

achieved by the students, as well as for ascertaining the degree of fulfillment of the state educational requirements and the knowledge and skills embedded in the curricula.

The presence of a ***national system for external assessment*** allows for comparing the achievements of the students from one and the same graduation group in different schools, to draw conclusions about the quality of teaching at the school and about the quality of work of the individual teacher, to compare the results of the students from different graduation groups, to draw conclusions about the trends in improvement of the quality of education on national scale.

The National Programme *Caring for Every Student* aims at enhancing the quality of the educational process through ensuring differentiated care for the personal development of children and students according to their individual and educational needs through:

Creation of conditions for expression of the students with talents, abilities and interests in a certain field of knowledge;

Provision of additional opportunities for enhancing the achievements of students who have repeated problems with mastering the syllabi;

Provision of pedagogic support to children from the preparatory groups for reaching preparedness for school.

It is carried out through activities organized in the following modules:

Module 1 Provision of training to talented students for participation in Olympiad contests students;

Module 2 Provision of additional training to children in the preparatory groups;

Module 3 Provision of additional training to students in the primary level of basic education for enhancing the level of their achievements in the general education training;

Module 4 Provision of additional training to students in the pre-secondary level of basic education for enhancing the level of achievements of in general education training;

In this respect projects are also elaborated under the ***National strategy for encouragement and improvement of literacy during the period 2014-2020.***

Prospects for educational order after the year 2015

What are the major national and international *development trends, factors and issues*, which will influence education in your country in the future?

The Strategic framework and objectives for development in the European Union during the period until 2020 are outlined in the Strategy *Europe 2020*. The National programme for reforms in the Republic of Bulgaria is a major strategic document at national

level, in which are embedded the major directions in the development of educational policies until the year 2020. The objectives of the Programme encompass the areas of various sector policies in pursuance of the Strategy *Europe 2020*.

In accordance with the Recommendation of the Council of the European Union of 28 June 2011, concerning the policies for reduction of early school leaving (2011/C 191/01), as well as with the EU strategic framework for cooperation in the area of education and training in pursuance of National Objective: Share of early leavers of the educational system of 11% until 2020, embedded in the National programme for reforms in the Republic of Bulgaria, in October 2013 a Strategy is adopted for reducing the share of early leavers of the educational system /2013-2020/. The strategy envisages measures for unification and synchronization of the efforts of the institutions in an overall integrated approach for addressing the challenges related to this phenomenon. For attainment of the objectives underlying the Strategy during the period until the year 2020 work will be completed along three lines: prevention (prevention of the reasons), intervention (creation of conditions for restriction) and compensation (support of re-inclusion).

What is the best manner in which the new trends and strategies in the area of education could be implemented? What type of system, structure, organization, mechanisms, institutional and individual capacity and competences will be necessary in order to initiate them?

The effects expected from the implementation of the policies embedded in the Strategy for reduction of the share of early leavers of the educational system (2013-2020) are related to the fulfillment of the national objective until the year 2020 - below 11%, reduction of social exclusion, enhancing the quality of the workforce and the welfare of citizens. The elaboration and implementation of overall, wide-ranging and efficient policies for reducing the vulnerability of risk groups is related to the research, analysis and systematization of the specific principles for early school leaving and (mapping) the necessary measures for retention at school.

It is necessary to ensure a unified and reliable database and the implementation of policies at all levels – regional, municipal and school and for guaranteeing the individual approach to each individual case of early school leaving.

APPENDIX No. 1

Information about educational structure, literacy and LLL participation of the population at the age of 15-24 completed years,

under Objectives 3 and 4 of Annex 3 Proposed annotated general structure of the national report for Education for All 2015

Relative share of the population at the age of 15 - 24 completed years, as per education degree

Age groups	15-19			20-24			15-24		
Year	2001	2011	Change in percentage points	2001	2011	Change in percentage points	2001	2011	Change in percentage points
Without education	2,11	2,94	0,83	1,48	3,04	1,56	1,78	2,99	1,21
Out of which: never attended school	:	1,23	-	:	1,53	-	:	1,40	-
Primary education	12,81	7,40	-5,41	5,90	4,15	-1,75	9,24	5,56	-3,67
Basic education	61,38	71,73	10,35	17,18	12,59	-4,59	38,52	38,37	-0,15
Secondary education	23,45	17,93	-5,52	67,56	69,69	2,13	46,26	47,13	0,87
Higher education (Bachelor and Master)	0,00	:	-	7,50	10,53	-	3,88	5,94	-
Higher education (Bachelor)	:	N/A	-	5,59	N/A	-	2,89	N/A	-
Higher education (master)	0,00	N/A	-	1,91	N/A	-	0,99	N/A	-
Higher education (PhD)	:	N/A	-	:	N/A	-	:	N/A	-
Unspecified	0,25	N/A	-	0,39	N/A	-	0,32	N/A	-

NA – not applicable/no data have been ordered, : - No data, - Not calculated

Source : National Statistical Institute, Census 2011 and Census 2001

Number of relative share (%) of the population at the age of 15-24 completed years, who have defined themselves as illiterate per ethnic group:

Age groups	Total	15-19			20 - 24			15-24		
Unit of measurement	Number	Number	Rel. share (%) to the age group	Rel. share (%) to the ethnic group	Ероў	Rel. share (%) to the age group	Rel. share (%) to the ethnic group	Ероў	Rel. share (%) to the age group	Rel. share (%) to the ethnic group
Total	6766337	7413	100,00	0,11	11084	100,00	0,16	18497	100,00	0,27
Bulgarian	5294181	1349	18,20	0,03	2256	20,35	0,04	3605	19,49	0,07
Turkish	534406	991	13,37	0,19	1550	13,98	0,29	2541	13,74	0,48
Roma	263824	3485	47,01	1,32	5178	46,72	1,96	8663	46,83	3,28
Other, undetermined, unspecified	673926	1555	20,98	0,23	2100	18,95	0,31	3655	19,76	0,54

Source : NSI, Census 2011

Participation of the population at the age of 15-24 completed years in formal

education and in informal learning per gender

Year	2003	2004	2005	2006	2007	2008	2009	2010	2011	2012
Participation in formal education and informal learning - total										
15-24	52,7	55,6	55,9	46,1	48,3	50,0	47,7	48,6	49,3	50,1
Men	51,4	53,9	54,6	45,5	46,7	48,0	45,7	46,2	46,4	47,8
Women	54,1	57,3	57,1	46,8	49,9	52,0	49,7	51,2	52,3	52,4
Out of them - with basic and lower education										
15-24	64,9	68,2	68,6	57,8	61,2	62,2	59,0	62,3	63,2	61,3
Men	65,6	68,5	69,5	57,5	61,7	63,6	60,4	62,9	64,8	62,9
Women	64,2	67,9	67,7	58,2	60,8	60,8	57,5	61,7	61,6	59,5
Out of them - with secondary education and college										
15-24	38,4	39,0	39,8	32,3	33,8	36,8	36,8	36,2	39,2	42,5
Men	32,6	33,2	34,2	29,6	28,5	30,2	31,2	30,7	32,5	36,6
Women	44,3	45,1	45,6	35,1	39,1	43,8	43,3	42,4	46,6	48,9
Out of them - with higher education										
15-24	17,7	25,8	26,5	21,9	23,0	26,7	20,9	20,4	27,8	31,0
Men	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	34,8
Women	:	:	21,8	:	23,3	28,5	19,5	:	28,6	28,5
Participation in formal education - total										
15-24	52,3	55,3	55,7	51,9	54,2	55,3	53,8	54,1	54,8	55,5
Men	50,8	53,7	54,5	51,4	52,2	53,0	51,5	51,3	51,3	52,4
Women	53,8	57,1	56,9	52,3	56,3	57,8	56,3	56,9	58,6	58,9
Out of them - with basic and lower education										
15-24	64,9	68,2	68,6	67,5	71,5	71,8	69,8	72,1	71,6	69,7
Men	65,5	68,5	69,5	67,9	72,2	73,5	71,7	73,5	73,7	71,4
Women	64,2	67,9	67,6	67,0	70,9	69,9	67,8	70,7	69,5	67,9
Out of them - with secondary education and college										
15-24	37,5	38,5	39,5	34,7	36,2	39,0	39,7	38,7	43,1	46,3
Men	31,2	32,7	33,8	31,6	30,0	31,5	33,2	32,4	35,2	39,0
Women	43,8	44,7	45,2	38,0	42,7	47,0	47,3	45,9	52,2	54,5
Out of them - with higher education										
15-24	:	25,1	25,4	21,5	22,7	26,3	20,6	20,3	29,1	32,6
Men	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	35,0
Women	:	:	20,7	:	:	27,7	19,7	:	29,7	31,0
Participation in informal learning - total										
15-24	2,6	1,2	0,6	1,0	0,8	1,4	1,2	1,3	0,9	1,1
Men	2,2	1,2	:	0,8	:	1,1	1,0	1,1	:	:
Women	2,9	1,2	0,8	1,2	1,1	1,6	1,4	1,5	1,2	1,3
Out of them - with basic and lower education										
15-24	2,4	1,0	:	0,9	:	1,2	1,1	1,4	1,0	:
Men	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:
Women	3,2	:	:	:	:	1,5	:	1,6	:	:
Out of them - with secondary education and college										
15-24	2,8	:	:	1,0	:	1,5	1,2	1,1	0,9	1,3
Men	3,2	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:
Women	:	:	:	:	:	1,7	:	:	:	:
Out of them - with higher education										
15-24	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:
Men	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:
Women	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:

: - no data available, or data of low statistical accuracy

Number of the population at the age of 20 – 24 per degree of completed education, regions and municipalities

Regions Municipalities	Total	Degree of completed education					Never attended school
		Higher	Secondary	Basic	Primary	Not completed primary	
TOTAL FOR THE COUNTRY	488807	51480	340648	61552	20279	7351	7497
BLAGOEVGRAD	24382	2135	17632	3373	774	254	214
BANSKO	802	80	540	147	28	3	4
BELITSA	730	54	371	261	36	5	3
BLAGOEVGRAD	8364	954	6873	412	69	27	29
GOTSE DELCHEV	2011	167	1279	497	52	7	9
GARMEN	1235	49	666	368	83	42	27
KRESNA	299	19	231	42	3	..	..
PETRICH	3383	261	2399	451	156	72	44
RAZLOG	1207	114	807	182	74	13	17
SANDANSKI	2458	203	1766	294	120	39	36
SATOVCHA	1155	68	877	187	13	5	5
SIMITLI	1004	68	693	198	33	7	5
STRUMYANI	318	8	169	40	57	26	18
HADZHIDIMOVO	585	41	423	91	12	6	12
YAKORUDA	831	49	538	203	38	..	..
BURGAS	26150	2455	16638	4535	1322	553	647
AYTOS	1880	105	1103	432	130	63	47
BURGAS	13353	1696	9674	1242	307	188	246
KAMENO	602	19	313	161	54	11	44
KARNOBAT	1547	114	881	325	138	43	46
MALKO TARNOVO							
ТЪРХОБО	179	11	73	42	35	11	7
NESEBAR	1303	113	877	202	75	20	16
POMORIE	1794	128	971	496	106	58	35
PRIMORSKO	387	26	243	74	32	5	7
RUEN	2094	60	1005	797	146	51	35
SOZOPOL	740	64	390	230	39	5	12
SREDETS	936	35	443	208	115	42	93
SUNGURLARE	762	27	335	227	90	35	48
TSAREVO	573	57	330	99	55	21	11
VARNA	34011	4185	23971	3609	1281	473	492
AVREN	460	14	204	131	74	14	23
AKSAKOVO	1269	52	699	405	76	20	17
BELOSLAV	694	27	524	110	28	..	..
BYALA	216	14	112	34	25	26	5
VARNA	26127	3904	19714	1598	434	225	252
VETRINO	243	8	166	47	15	7	-
VALCHI DOL	491	19	259	143	40	20	10
DEVNYA	582	17	381	126	34	15	9
DOLNI CHIFLIK	1384	24	546	428	225	74	87
DALGOPOL	854	29	424	207	143	26	25
PROVADIA	1306	69	720	285	146	37	49
SUVOROVO	385	8	222	95	41	..	..
VELIKO TARNOVO	23350	2677	17918	1979	514	121	141
VELIKO TARNOVO	9429	1125	7797	414	49	12	32
GORNA ORYAHOVITSA	2457	275	1720	356	71	20	15
ELENA	488	27	283	118	32	4	24
ZLATARITSA	221	12	128	53	23	..	..
LYASKOVETS	700	70	537	68	20	..	..
PAVLIKENI	1152	85	666	269	92	25	15

POLSKI TRAMBESH	708	37	399	169	70	20	13
SVISHTOV	7355	1011	5963	317	40	12	12
STRAZHITSA	732	29	363	194	108	19	19
SUHINDOL	108	6	62	21	9	5	5
VIDIN	4400	291	2897	864	190	80	78
BELOGRADCHIK	301	14	175	49	39	8	16
BOYNITSA	20	..	13	5	-	-	..
BREGOVO	229	16	150	38	9	..	..
VIDIN	2857	228	1999	512	62	23	33
GRAMADA	55	..	32	..	..	..	-
DIMOVO	327	4	157	108	31	15	12
KULA	166	12	99	34	6	4	11
MAKRESH	31	-	19	..	..	-	-
NOVO SELO	104	3	83	14	4	-	-
RUZHINTSI	224	7	130	63	9	12	3
CHUPRENE	86	..	40	18	20	..	..
VRATSA	9424	682	6393	1697	379	138	135
BOROVAN	269	4	139	94	27	..	..
BYALA SLATINA	1275	64	763	333	70	25	20
VRATSA	3796	394	2723	519	84	42	34
KOZLODUY	1186	87	796	179	75	30	19
KRIVODOL	403	11	212	121	32	11	16
MEZDRA	1086	63	849	126	21	6	21
MIZIA	363	16	257	69	17	..	..
ОРЯХОБО	515	21	317	133	27	8	9
ROMAN	328	15	202	77	14	10	10
HAYREDIN	203	7	135	46	12	..	..
GABROVO	6369	600	4930	682	100	30	27
GABROVO	3700	342	3038	289	21	..	..
DRYANOVO	443	47	311	57	20	..	..
SEVLIEVO	1756	165	1216	285	56	17	17
TRYAVNA	470	46	365	51	3	..	..
DOBRICH	11217	1017	6565	2064	936	307	328
BALCHIK	1272	82	684	276	136	49	45
GENERAL-TOSHEVO	774	59	394	140	97	39	45
DOBRICH-CITY	5573	683	3920	643	194	62	71
DOBRICHKA	1190	31	411	410	195	71	72
KAVARNA	850	90	456	126	121	36	21
KRUSHARI	257	7	72	85	39	19	35
TERVEL	1048	47	449	351	136	..	..
SHABLA	253	18	179	33	18	..	..
KARDZHALI	9509	769	5998	2208	297	116	121
ARDINO	632	44	452	121	5	5	5
DZHEBEL	560	37	384	127	3	..	..
KIRKOVO	1262	73	812	308	41	18	10
KRUMOVGRAD	1145	68	610	378	66	14	9
KARDZHALI	4163	373	2638	863	154	62	73
MOMCHILGRAD	1086	119	691	228	23	14	11
CHERNOOCHENE	661	55	411	183	5	..	..
KYUSTENDIL	6073	477	4256	978	199	93	70
BOBOV DOL	479	16	340	78	19	13	13
BOBOSHEVO	146	11	104	28	..	..	-
DUPNITSA	2070	170	1438	356	60	22	24
KOCHERINOVO	209	17	148	31	10	..	-
KYUSTENDIL	2604	219	1803	402	96	52	32
NEVESTINO	58	..	46	8	..	-	-
RILA	111	..	83	10	..	-	-
SAPAREVA BANYA	383	27	288	58	7	..	..
TREKLYANO	13	-	6	7	-	-	-
LOVECH	6676	552	4166	1223	411	181	143

APRILTSI	113	9	94	..	..	-	-
LETNITSA	178	14	82	..	..	6	4
LOVECH	2211	263	1578	256	69	26	19
LUKOVIT	1027	41	422	280	150	73	61
TETEVEN	1187	65	729	302	61	9	21
TROYAN	1305	138	977	148	29	9	4
UGARCHIN	277	5	138	71	20	30	13
YABLANITSA	378	17	146	116	50	28	21
MONTANA	7316	403	4809	1401	482	136	85
BERKOVITSA	934	38	517	220	91	38	30
BOYCHINOVTSI	463	7	291	106	35	18	6
BRUSARTSI	241	3	157	64	8	3	6
VALCHEDRAM	466	14	237	143	56	11	5
VARSHETS	435	35	216	81	80	19	4
GEORGI DAMYANOVO	93	..	67	23	..	-	-
LOM	1434	66	961	322	60	13	12
MEDKOVETS	152	5	75	56	13	-	3
MONTANA	2776	222	2074	309	123	30	18
TCHIPROVTSI	140	..	112	19	-	-	..
YAKIMOVO	182	..	102	58	..	4	-
PAZARDZHIK	16967	1292	9601	3467	1563	519	525
BATAK	313	32	213	43	9	..	..
BELOVO	457	35	353	54	13	..	..
BRATSIGOVO	579	32	320	114	57	21	35
VELINGRAD	2569	169	1557	622	86	54	81
LESICHOVO	274	3	123	83	42	10	13
PAZARDZHIK	7112	653	3719	1381	831	287	241
PANAGYURISHTIE	1387	94	1039	146	72	22	14
PESHTERA	1172	107	671	160	112	37	85
RAKITOVO	1092	36	536	418	76	16	10
SEPTEMVRI	1752	114	905	411	232	59	31
STRELTCHA	260	17	165	35	33	..	..
PERNIK	6260	416	4864	732	159	49	40
BREZNIK	280	7	208	47	12	4	..
ZEMEN	93	..	66	20	..	-	..
KOVATCHEVSTI	45	..	39	4	-	..	-
PERNIK	4614	348	3650	491	84	22	19
RADOMIR	1037	51	817	136	22	5	6
TRAN	191	6	84	34	40	18	9
PLEVEN	13949	1159	9353	2137	783	228	289
BELENE	557	46	375	87	33	-	16
GULYANTSI	498	24	310	98	45	9	12
DOLNA MITROPOLIYA							
МИТРОПОЛИЯ	916	35	517	243	82	16	23
DOLNI DABNIK	543	22	309	110	51	29	22
ISKAR	338	9	206	92	22	4	5
KNEZHA	733	51	486	106	57	24	9
LEVSKI	951	63	578	202	72	14	22
NIKOPOL	351	18	203	74	34	13	9
PLEVEN	7259	799	5265	726	256	90	123
PORDIM	299	9	180	75	19	..	15
CHERVEN BRYAG	1504	83	924	324	112	28	33
PLOVDIV	45089	4585	30853	5458	2329	894	970
ASENOVGRAD	3835	399	2737	436	105	79	79
BREZOVO	333	10	177	61	48	20	17
KALOYANOVO	587	22	359	121	46	16	23
KARLOVO	2974	178	1930	374	242	102	148
KRICHIM	559	35	300	93	100	17	14
KUKLEN	394	35	292	45	..	6	..
LAKI	156	12	125	11	..	-	..

MARITSA	2071	125	1177	408	174	98	89
PERUSHTITSA	306	8	157	61	49	17	14
PLOVDIV	24762	3142	17951	2147	817	312	393
PARVOMAY	1381	96	796	321	114	28	26
RAKOVSKI	1925	106	1233	319	157	38	72
RODOPI	1800	161	1282	260	61	24	12
SADOVO	947	35	459	239	133	48	33
SOPOT	572	50	451	49	14	3	5
STAMBOLIYSKI	1344	84	726	268	177	65	24
SAEDINENIE	584	49	341	125	50	13	6
HISARYA	559	38	360	120	30	8	3
RAZGRAD	7089	527	4373	1556	412	126	95
ZAVET	643	31	356	181	57	12	6
ISPERIH	1314	94	678	327	145	40	30
KUBRAT	975	60	527	272	71	27	18
LOZNITSA	546	27	366	123	22	..	..
RAZGRAD	2848	267	2014	449	64	31	23
SAMUIL	433	25	216	127	42	8	15
TSAR KALOYAN	330	23	216	77	11	..	..
RUSSE	14809	1556	10656	1858	470	150	119
BOROVO	304	14	137	103	36	10	4
BYALA	667	56	378	120	81	16	16
VETOVO	667	36	379	137	73	29	13
DVE MOGILI	527	28	285	125	53	12	24
IVANOVO	401	31	230	104	29	..	..
RUSSE	11409	1352	8780	1048	130	54	45
SLIVO POLE	611	28	340	161	51	19	12
TSENOVO	223	11	127	60	17	..	..
SILISTRA	6677	606	3871	1299	535	171	195
ALFATAR	133	4	73	27	15	11	3
GLAVINITSA	573	54	246	187	61	16	9
DULOVO	1777	124	871	447	155	76	104
KAYNARDZHA	384	9	91	111	137	24	12
SILISTRA	2838	345	2012	339	81	22	39
SITOVO	242	16	114	53	27	10	22
TUTRAKAN	730	54	464	135	59	12	6
SLIVEN	11983	729	5901	2159	1489	823	882
KOTEL	1269	37	475	424	203	89	41
NOVA ZAGORA	2308	102	1014	510	384	174	124
SLIVEN	7547	547	4106	1130	774	471	519
TVARDITSA	859	43	306	95	128	89	198
SMOLYAN	7066	666	5618	640	69	23	50
BANITE	210	26	161	23	-	-	-
BORINO	217	14	171	32	-	-	-
DEVIN	703	68	526	92	..	-	..
DOSPAT	640	41	527	63	..	..	..
ZLATOGRAD	688	56	593	35	-	..	..
MADAN	760	39	613	101	..	-	..
NEDELINO	434	32	373	23	..	..	..
RUDOZEM	569	60	443	60	-	..	..
SMOLYAN	2443	281	1900	174	51	18	19
CHEPELARE	402	49	311	37	5	-	-
SOFIA-REGION	13035	882	9065	2051	676	183	178
ANTON	80	4	61	12	..	-	..
BOZHURISHTA	352	30	289	29	..	-	..
BOTEVGRAD	1831	188	1241	264	89	24	25
GODECH	248	13	198	33	..	-	..
GORNA MALINA	316	17	247	32	13	..	..
DOLNA BANYA	295	15	161	77	28	4	10
DRAGOMAN	208	10	170	24	..	..	-

ELIN PELIN	1225	88	932	145	37	14	9
ETROPOLE	660	63	488	78	26	..	..
ZLATITSA	368	23	287	40	11	..	..
IHTIMAN	1077	34	511	270	174	50	38
KOPRIVSHITSA	123	9	99	9	6	-	-
KOSTENETS	640	47	472	64	22	18	17
KOSTINBROD	935	69	752	96	14	..	..
MIRKOVO	116	5	81	21	..	..	-
PIRDOP	452	38	346	50	14	..	..
PRAVETS	459	29	243	109	51	9	18
SAMOKOV	1958	116	1115	512	139	37	39
SVOGE	1049	45	876	113	..	-	..
SLIVNITSA	498	32	399	54	..	..	..
CHAVDAR	75	..	55	9	7	..	..
CHELOPECH	70	6	42	10	..	..	..
SOFIA	118844	18548	93382	5353	894	357	310
SOFIA-CAPITAL CITY	118844	18548	93382	5353	894	357	310
STARA ZAGORA	18905	1415	12346	2731	1338	538	537
BRATYA DASKALОВI	434	5	120	161	75	53	20
GURKOVO	361	7	136	65	117	21	15
GALABOVO	668	19	445	139	44	..	..
KAZANLAK	3886	287	2746	514	216	57	66
MAGLIZH	565	13	232	109	89	62	60
NIKOLAEVO	268	5	83	47	62	57	14
OPAN	68	-	28	22	11	..	..
PAVEL BANYA	836	20	403	208	124	35	46
RADNEVO	1070	57	783	133	44	21	32
STARA ZAGORA	9648	953	6799	1094	410	178	214
CHIRPAN	1101	49	571	239	146	40	56
TARGOVISHTЕ	6842	425	4068	1753	421	97	78
ANTONOVO	394	17	174	116	60	14	13
OMURTAG	1361	68	715	424	111	19	24
OPAKA	424	26	275	107	13	..	..
POPOVO	1411	85	858	343	79	..	..
TARGOVISHTЕ	3252	229	2046	763	158	37	19
HASKOVO	13412	1087	8184	2528	984	302	327
DIMITROVGRAD	2799	201	1841	477	171	59	50
IVAYLOVGRAD	352	20	255	62	9	..	..
LYUBIMETS	516	29	263	83	91	33	17
MADZHAROVO	76	5	50	12	3	..	..
MINERALNI BANI	359	30	235	80	8	6	-
SVILENGRAD	1307	137	807	180	137	16	30
SIMEONOVGRAD	551	11	247	113	82	42	56
STAMBOLOVO	351	9	165	134	27	7	9
TOPOLOVGRAD	513	29	298	138	36	6	6
HARMANLI	1445	93	777	339	151	46	39
HASKOVO	5143	523	3246	910	269	82	113
SHUMEN	11921	783	8080	2003	737	185	133
VELIKI PRES LAV ПРЕСЛАВ	786	36	545	144	48	6	7
VENETS	494	22	249	143	55	18	7
VARBITSА	669	15	276	231	116	19	12
KAOLINOVО	823	21	397	251	104	25	25
KASPICHAN	468	19	258	125	51	11	4
NIKOLA KOZLEVO	427	14	179	112	73	28	21
NOVI PAZAR	1011	60	650	170	93	22	16
SMYADOVO	355	14	197	101	31	9	3
HITRINO	333	10	202	85	29	4	3
SHUMEN	6555	572	5127	641	137	43	35
YAMBOL	7082	561	4260	1214	535	224	288

BOLYAROVO	183	7	84	51	25	9	7
ELHOVO	797	46	515	162	52	14	8
STRALDZHA	660	25	235	157	150	40	53
TUNDZHA	1052	44	556	250	88	45	69
YAMBOL	4390	439	2870	594	220	116	151

.. - The data are confidential pursuant to Article 25 of the Statistics Act, No data available, - No data available

Source: NSI, Census 2011

Participation of the population at the age of 15-24 completed years in formal education and informal learning per gender

Year	2003	2004	2005	2006	2007	2008	2009	2010	2011	2012
Participation in formal education and informal learning - total										
15-24	52.7	55.6	55.9	46.1	48.3	50.0	47.7	48.6	49.3	50.1
Male	51.4	53.9	54.6	45.5	46.7	48.0	45.7	46.2	46.4	47.8
Female	54.1	57.3	57.1	46.8	49.9	52.0	49.7	51.2	52.3	52.4
Out of whom - with basic and lower education										
15-24	64.9	68.2	68.6	57.8	61.2	62.2	59.0	62.3	63.2	61.3
Male	65.6	68.5	69.5	57.5	61.7	63.6	60.4	62.9	64.8	62.9
Female	64.2	67.9	67.7	58.2	60.8	60.8	57.5	61.7	61.6	59.5
Out of whom - with secondary education and college										
15-24	38.4	39.0	39.8	32.3	33.8	36.8	36.8	36.2	39.2	42.5
Male	32.6	33.2	34.2	29.6	28.5	30.2	31.2	30.7	32.5	36.6
Female	44.3	45.1	45.6	35.1	39.1	43.8	43.3	42.4	46.6	48.9
Out of whom -with higher education										
15-24	17.7	25.8	26.5	21.9	23.0	26.7	20.9	20.4	27.8	31.0
Male :	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	34.8
Female :	:	:	21.8 :	:	23.3 :	28.5 :	19.5 :	:	28.6 :	28.5
Participation in formal education - total										
15-24	52.3	55.3	55.7	51.9	54.2	55.3	53.8	54.1	54.8	55.5
Male	50.8	53.7	54.5	51.4	52.2	53.0	51.5	51.3	51.3	52.4
Female	53.8	57.1	56.9	52.3	56.3	57.8	56.3	56.9	58.6	58.9
Out of whom - with basic and lower education										
15-24	64.9	68.2	68.6	67.5	71.5	71.8	69.8	72.1	71.6	69.7
Male	65.5	68.5	69.5	67.9	72.2	73.5	71.7	73.5	73.7	71.4
Female	64.2	67.9	67.6	67.0	70.9	69.9	67.8	70.7	69.5	67.9
Out of whom with secondary education and college										
15-24	37.5	38.5	39.5	34.7	36.2	39.0	39.7	38.7	43.1	46.3
Male	31.2	32.7	33.8	31.6	30.0	31.5	33.2	32.4	35.2	39.0
Female	43.8	44.7	45.2	38.0	42.7	47.0	47.3	45.9	52.2	54.5
Out of whom - with higher education										
15-24	:	25.1	25.4	21.5	22.7	26.3	20.6	20.3	29.1	32.6
Male :	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	35.0
Female :	:	:	20.7 :	:	27.7 :	19.7 :	:	:	29.7 :	31.0
Participation in informal learning - total										
15-24	2.6	1.2	0.6	1.0	0.8	1.4	1.2	1.3	0.9	1.1
Male	2.2	1.2 :	:	0.8 :	:	1.1	1.0	1.1 :	:	:
Female	2.9	1.2	0.8	1.2	1.1	1.6	1.4	1.5	1.2	1.3
Out of whom - with basic and lower education										
15-24	2.4	1.0 :	:	0.9 :	:	1.2	1.1	1.4	1.0 :	:
Male :	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:
Female	3.2 :	:	:	:	:	1.5 :	:	1.6 :	:	:
Out of whom - with secondary education and college										
15-24	2.8 :	:	:	1.0 :	:	1.5	1.2	1.1	0.9	1.3
Male	3.2 :	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:
Female :	:	:	:	:	:	1.7 :	:	:	:	:
Out of whom -with higher education										
15-24	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:
Male	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:
Female	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:	:

	Total	15-19		20-24		15-24	
	Number	Number	Relative share (%)	Number	Relative share (%)	Number	Relative share (%)
Total	7,928,901	537,284	100.00	575,671	100.00	1,112,955	100.00
Without education	85,977	11,334	2.11	8,497	1.48	19,831	1.78
Primary education	1,372,722	68,823	12.81	33,961	5.90	102,784	9.24
Basic education	2,049,443	329,805	61.38	98,896	17.18	428,701	38.52
Secondary education	2,826,821	125,996	23.45	388,895	67.56	514,891	46.26
Higher education (Bachelor and Master)	1,050,534	8	0.00	43,197	7.50	43,205	3.88
Higher education (Bachelor)	702,999	:	:	32,188	5.59	32,188	2.89
Higher education (Master)	333,671	8	0.00	11,009	1.91	11,017	0.99
Higher education (PhD)	13,864	:	:	:	:	:	:
Unspecified	496,493	1,318	0.25	2,225	0.39	3,543	0.32

	Total	15-19		20-24		15-24	
	Number	Number	Relative share (%)	Number	Relative share (%)	Number	Relative share (%)
Total	7,928,901	537,284	100.00	575,671	100.00	1,112,955	100.00
male	3,862,465	276,146	51.40	295,399	51.31	571,545	51.35
female	4,066,436	261,138	48.60	280,272	48.69	541,410	48.65
Without education	85,977	11,334	2.11	8,497	1.48	19,831	1.78
male	46,911	5,647	1.05	3,988	0.69	9,635	0.87
female	39,066	5,687	1.06	4,509	0.78	10,196	0.92
Primary education	1,372,722	68,823	12.81	33,961	5.90	102,784	9.24
male	617,611	36,344	6.76	17,085	2.97	53,429	4.80
female	755,111	32,479	6.05	16,876	2.93	49,355	4.43
Basic education	2,049,443	329,805	61.38	98,896	17.18	428,701	38.52
male	1,036,099	170,327	31.70	55,963	9.72	226,290	20.33
female	1,013,344	159,478	29.68	42,933	7.46	202,411	18.19
Secondary education	2,826,821	125,996	23.45	388,895	67.56	514,891	46.26
male	1,461,679	63,234	11.77	208,869	36.28	272,103	24.45
female	1,365,142	62,762	11.68	180,026	31.27	242,788	21.81
Higher education (Bachelor and Master)	1,050,534	8	0.00	43,197	7.50	43,205	3.88
male	446,735	5	0.00	8,545	1.48	8,550	0.77
female	603,799	3	0.00	34,652	6.02	34,655	3.11
Higher education (Bachelor)	702,999	:	:	32,188	5.59	32,188	2.89
male	325,584	:	:	6,722	1.17	6,722	0.60
female	377,415	:	:	25,466	4.42	25,466	2.29
Higher education (Master)	333,671	8	0.00	11,009	1.91	11,017	0.99
male	112,424	5	0.00	1,823	0.32	1,828	0.16
female	221,247	3	0.00	9,186	1.60	9,189	0.83
Higher education (PhD)	13,864	:	:	:	:	:	:
male	8,727	:	:	:	:	:	:
female	5,137	:	:	:	:	:	:
Unspecified	496,493	1,318	0.25	2,225	0.39	3,543	0.32
male	253,430	589	0.11	949	0.16	1,538	0.14
female	243,063	729	0.14	1,276	0.22	2,005	0.18